

What Makes You, You? An Introduction to Personal Identity

An original lesson plan inspired by **Eric T. Olson's** the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy entry on *Personal Identity*. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy or Eric T. Olson. Explore the original course: <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/identity-personal/>

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 11-12 / Intro College

DURATION

60 minutes

TOPICS

Metaphysics

“What actually makes you the same person today that you were ten years ago — your body, your brain, your memories, or something else entirely?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain the three major theories of personal identity over time: animalism, psychological continuity theory, and the no-further-fact/reductionist view.
- Apply all three theories to a teleportation or brain-fission thought experiment to determine what each implies about survival.
- Evaluate whether personal identity is a determinate, all-or-nothing fact and defend a position using one of the thought experiments as evidence.

Materials Needed

- Handout describing three thought experiments: the classic teleporter, the fission (brain-split) case, and gradual brain replacement
- Whiteboard for a comparison chart of the three theories
- Small paper "person tokens" for visually mapping the fission case
- Exit ticket slips

Lesson Procedure

Hook: The Teleporter Malfunction

8 min

Present the classic scenario: a teleporter scans your body, destroys the original, and reconstructs an atom-for-atom copy on Mars. Ask whether you survived the trip, or whether you died and were replaced by a copy who merely believes he is you. Take a quick poll before moving on.

Direct Instruction: Three Theories of Sameness

15 min

Present animalism (you are identical with a living human organism, so identity tracks biological continuity), psychological continuity theory (identity tracks overlapping chains of memory, personality, and intention, following Locke and Parfit), and the no-further-fact/reductionist view (Parfit's claim that there is no deep further fact of identity beyond physical and psychological continuities, so identity questions can sometimes have no determinate answer).

Small-Group Analysis: The Fission Case

20 min

Present the classic fission thought experiment, where a person's brain is split and each half is placed in a new body, both surviving with equal psychological continuity to the original. Groups work out what each of the three theories must say about this case, and identify the strain each theory faces — for instance, psychological continuity theory seems to require "identity" to become non-transitive, since you'd apparently be identical to two people who aren't identical to each other.

Whole-Class Share and Debate

12 min

Groups present their analysis of the fission case. Contrast it with the gradual brain-replacement case, and ask whether identity really requires a sharp yes/no answer or whether it can be a matter of degree.

Closure

5 min

Exit ticket: students state their verdict on the teleporter case and name one open question they still have about personal identity.

Discussion Questions

- 1 In the teleporter case, is destroying the original and creating a perfect duplicate the same as surviving, or is it death followed by replacement?
- 2 In the fission case, can you be identical to two different resulting people if those two people aren't identical to each other? What does this suggest about whether personal identity obeys ordinary logical rules like transitivity?
- 3 If Parfit is right that "identity is not what matters" and what we really care about is psychological continuity, which can come in degrees or split, should that change how we feel about death, teleportation, or radical life extension?
- 4 Does animalism avoid the fission and teleporter puzzles more easily than psychological theories — and if so, is that a point in its favor, or does it just relocate the puzzle to cases like biological twinning?
- 5 Should our practical concerns — moral responsibility, concern for our future selves, keeping promises — track strict metaphysical identity, or could they track something looser, like psychological continuity, even when identity itself is indeterminate?

Assessment

Students write a short essay applying one of the three theories of personal identity to a scenario they design themselves — a gradual replacement, a duplication, or a memory-loss case — and explain what that theory implies about whether the resulting person is "the same" individual. Grade on correct application of the chosen theory's actual criteria, not on the conclusion reached.

Extension Activity

Have students watch or read a summary of a film, novel, or news story involving identity change, duplication, or memory loss (such as a mind-uploading or amnesia narrative) and write a short analysis of which theory of personal identity that story implicitly assumes.

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